SOUR TASTE IN SWEET SAGA

The fat's in the fire as an investigation report in the Tirupati laddu case gives both the ruling TDP and rival YSRCP fuel for another battle. Meanwhile, devotees are now buying more laddus than ever

BY **PRASAD NICHENAMETLA**



FOR ABOUT ONE AND A HALF YEARS NOW, Andhra Pradesh politics has revolved around the ubiquitous laddu. No ordinary laddu, this famed Tirupati one is divine, offered first to the state's most venerated deity—Lord Venkateshwara—and consumed as *mahaprasadam* by lakhs of devotees daily.

The Tirupati laddu is tied to the religious sentiments of Hindus everywhere. Such is the tradition and distinctive process of making it at the *potu* (the dedicated kitchen within the temple premises), that the 'Tirupati laddu' received its own GI tag in 2009. The Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD), the temple administrative body, also zealously guards its fair name by cracking down on vendors passing off fake products as the original.

Now, Andhra Pradesh chief minister Chandrababu Naidu is accusing predecessor Jagan Mohan Reddy's regime of having done something even worse, "utterly deplorable", as he calls it—allowing the Tirupati laddus to be made with inferior ingredients, specifically fake ghee. Naidu, who heads the Telugu Desam Party, the BJP's chief ally at the Centre, alleges that a whopping 200.1 million laddus were made with adulterated ghee during the Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP) government's tenure between 2019 and 2024.

Speaking in the state assembly at Amaravati last week, Naidu charged that some 5.97 million kilos of tainted ghee were used, resulting in misappropriation of Rs 234.5 crore of TTD funds. This is even as all 11 YSRCP members, including Jagan, continue to boycott assembly proceedings, in protest against being denied 'Opposition status'. The figures Naidu is citing are from the findings of the CBI-monitored special investigation team (SIT), which filed its final supplementary charge sheet in the fake ghee case in a local court at Nellore in January. The report dispelled the earlier claims by Naidu and his deputy CM,